

“Come, Ye Thankful People, Come”

Text: Henry Alford, 1844

Meter: 7.7.7.7 *D*

Suggested Tune: ST. GEORGE’S
WINDSOR

1. Come, ye thankful people, come,
raise the song of harvest home!
All is safely gathered in,
ere the winter storms begin.
God, our maker, doth provide
for our wants to be supplied.
Come to God’s own temple, come,
raise the song of harvest home!

2. For the world is God’s own field,
fruit unto His praise to yield;
wheat and tares together sown,
unto joy or sorrow grown;
first the blade, and then the ear,
then the full corn shall appear;
grant, O harvest-Lord, that we
wholesome grain and pure may be!

3. For the Lord our God shall come
and shall take His harvest home;
from His field shall in that day
all offenses purge away.
Give His angels charge at last
in the fire the tares to cast,
but the fruitful ears to store
in His garner evermore.

4. Even so, Lord, quickly come
to Your final harvest home;
gather all Your people in,
free from sorrow, free from sin;
there, forever purified,
in Your presence to abide.
Come, with all Your angels, come,
raise the glorious harvest home.

At the end of the liturgical year, we take time to prepare ourselves for the end times when the Son of Man will come again in glory to judge all people. At the same time of the year, people living in the Northern Hemisphere celebrate the end of a (hopefully) bountiful harvest season by giving thanks to God. This hymn brings both of those themes together into a single narrative, using the harvest as a metaphor for the final judgment.

Verse 1 is a call to gather God’s people together after the harvest. Since He has both given us life and provided us with what we need to sustain it, we assemble in a church to offer thanksgiving.

Verse 2 looks at the world through the lens of Christ’s parable of the Wheat and the Weeds (Mat. 13:24–30). God has sown good seed – righteous people – in His field. Those righteous people are made to joyfully bear good fruit, works of love. But alongside them have been sown weeds – people that do not intend to bear good fruit. God patiently watches each of us mature, letting the weeds grow alongside the wheat. We pray that we are the latter.

In verse 3, God comes to reap His harvest. According to the parable, the harvesters (the angels who come with Him on judgment day) are instructed to separate the weeds from the wheat. The weeds are cast into the fire to be burned while the wheat is saved in the storehouse. We too are to be eternally sent into either heaven or hell depending on our fruitfulness.

In the first verse, we told God’s people to come to God’s harvest home. In the final verse, we beckon God to come to His harvest home. But this time, we’re not referring to a church building; we’re

Reflection (Thanksgiving Day):

referring to heaven itself, and so we ask Him to let us in. Once there, we no longer have to worry about being in the presence of the weeds since we are kept safe in His glorious presence.